DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Reward or Consequence? What Gemul Really Means

Derech Hashem, Maamar Halkarim

Sefer: Maamar Halkarim by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal), printed at the end of Derech Hashem **Section:** Maamar Halkarim, essay 4: gemul, reward and punishment (first part) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 13 June 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Not reward and punishment

The fourth essay is titled BaGemul, usually translated "reward and punishment". The Rabbi began by saying the translation is not precise, and that this is an important principle. The idea of reward suggests "you do X, you get Y", a picture of delights waiting in the afterlife for every good deed, which he called a Christian notion. In Judaism the afterlife is simply the spiritual result of the choices a person made in life. A person who exercises every day does not get weight loss as a reward; it is the consequence. "It's the identity which you choose for yourself."

Punishment too is not what people imagine. The greatest punishment in the Torah is that there is no punishment: you simply cease to exist. A short period of purging in Gehinnom, up to twelve months, is minor by comparison. For everyone else, failing to work on yourself just means a more distant view.

The stadium and the Queen

He gave two familiar images. If you do not bother to get a good ticket for a big match and end up at the back of the stadium, that is not a punishment, just the result of not making the effort. And if Olam HaBa is an audience with the Queen, whether you stand on the balcony, in the front row or the second row depends on how much you have made yourself fit for her company.

A participant objected that coming late to a football match is a mistake, not a sin, so the comparison does not fit. The Rabbi explained that a sin does two things. First, it is something bad that needs purging, which happens in this world or in Gehinnom, and is temporary. More importantly, it distances you from God. "It makes you less royal." No amount of purging in Gehinnom will earn you a closer seat. A participant mentioned teshuvah, and the Rabbi agreed that this is the solution in this world: like a student who starts studying late but works hard enough to change everything.

Gemul: weaning and the camel

Why does the Ramhal use the word gemul and not sakhar veonesh? The Rabbi asked where the root first appears. In Parashat Vayera, Yishak "grew and was weaned", vayigamal, and Avraham made a feast on the day he was weaned. And a camel is a gamal. A weaned child no longer depends on its mother, and a camel is the animal that, once given water, can go for months without help.

This explains the phrase in the Amidah, gomel hasadim tovim, "who bestows good kindnesses". Is there such a thing as bad hesed? Yes: kindness that never lets the recipient stand on his own feet. That is why the Rambam ranks giving a person a job as the highest form of sedakah. In Kabbalah hesed is balanced by gevurah, restraint. The proof that unrestrained hesed is dangerous: the Torah calls a relationship between brother and sister "hesed", which Onkelos renders as disgrace, love that does not know its boundaries. God created the world with hesed, but to make room for a finite world He withdrew Himself, simsum, which is gevurah.

So gemul means what you have made of yourself, like the child who has become a "camel" able to stand alone. "That's what we mean when we talk about reward and punishment."

Two places for gemul

The Ramhal says humanity was set apart from all other species by the power of choice and the ability to draw down spiritual energy. Because we choose, our actions bring consequences, measure for measure. These come in two places: this world and the next.

The level a person reaches through his actions in this world is the level of closeness he will have for eternity. "You've had 120 years." The afterlife itself has two stages: the temporary world of souls (Gan Eden and Gehinnom, the next essay), and Olam HaBa, the renewed world after the resurrection, with body and soul together. The good we receive in this world is a taste of Gan Eden, and Gan Eden is a taste of Olam HaBa.

Children, grandchildren and Kaddish

A participant asked whether a person's place can change because of what his children and grandchildren do. The Rabbi said this is an important point. Kaddish is not "some kind of hocus pocus". When a child behaves in a certain way and clearly attributes it to a parent, that says something about the parent's essence and legacy. "The apple doesn't fall far from the tree." So a parent's identity can grow through the actions of descendants, as long as they are attributed to the parent. That is also why Kaddish said by a hired person is better than nothing but not ideal. It shows the person left a situation where someone would say Kaddish for him, but it cannot compare with a child or grandchild doing it.

Consequences in this world

The Ramhal then says that some misvot and some sins have consequences both in this world and the next, some only in the next, and some only in this world, all decided with perfect justice. Asked which are which, the Rabbi said, "I can't tell you."

A participant asked how this fits with the principle that there is no reward for misvot in this world. The Rabbi gave the Rambam's answer, which he called the true one. The blessings promised in the Torah are not a reward but tools to do the job properly, like a company that gives an employee a phone and accommodation. When God promises rain in its season, He is freeing our minds to serve Him, fast-tracking our service.

Summary

- Gemul is better translated as "consequences": the afterlife reflects the identity we built in this life.
- A sin needs temporary purging, but its real cost is distance from God, which Gehinnom cannot undo.
- Gemul shares a root with weaning and the camel: true kindness makes the recipient able to stand alone.
- A person's legacy can be raised by descendants who attribute their good deeds to him, which is the meaning of Kaddish.
- Blessings in this world, says the Rambam, are tools to serve God better, not the reward itself.

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